8-WEEK PLAN

Push / Pull / Legs

8 weeks, 6 days.

Days 6 a week **Session** 45–60 min **Equipment** Full gym
Version 2026-10-13

What this is

Push, pull, legs is the split I run when I want to be in the gym most days and still recover. The week divides the body by movement, not by muscle. Push days are chest, shoulders and triceps. Pull days are back, biceps and rear delts. Leg days are quads, hamstrings, glutes and calves. Each of the three gets two sessions a week, one heavy and one for volume, so every muscle is trained twice with three to four days between hits. That is the frequency where most intermediate lifters grow and the fatigue where they still recover. The intensity is capped. You stop two reps from failure on every set, and that cap is what makes six days a week possible. The eight weeks run as two four-week blocks. Three weeks of building, a light week, three more weeks from the new loads, then a light week with a re-test against your week 1 numbers. You finish with a logged number for every main lift, not a feeling.

Who it's for

- Lifters with one to three years of consistent training behind them
- People who can give five or six days a week to the gym
- Anyone with a full gym: barbells, dumbbells, cables, a leg press, a leg curl

Who it's not for

- Beginners. Six days of this before the basic lifts are learned is a lot of volume spent on bad reps. Run a three or four day plan first.
- Anyone sleeping under six hours a night. The frequency depends on recovery. Fix sleep first.
- Anyone who cannot reliably give at least five days. Three days of a six-day plan is a worse three-day plan than one built for three days.

Equipment: full gym. Sessions are capped at 60 minutes including the warm-up.

Before you start

Five rules. They are the plan.

1. **The week is decided before it starts.** Sunday night, or whatever your night before is, you know which session falls on which day. You do not decide in the morning.
2. **Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins.** Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water, salt and food. One number is noise. Weigh daily if you like, but the number you act on is the seven-day average.
3. **A missed day is data, not failure.** It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet. Record it and move on.
4. **Log every session.** Exercise, load, sets, reps. The plan works off the record. A session that isn't written down didn't happen for progression purposes.
5. **Progress is checked against the record, not against how you feel.** Tired weeks lie in both directions. The log doesn't.

Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights anywhere in this document. Week 1, session 1 of each day type is a load-finding session. For each exercise, work up to a load you can lift for the bottom of the rep range with two reps still left in you. If the range says 6 to 8, you want a weight where you hit 6 and could have done 8. That is your starting

load. Write it down. If you find it on the second or third working set rather than the first, fine. Week 1 is about finding the number, not hitting volume.

Two reps from failure means exactly that. If you think you can do 12, you stop at 10. If you think you can do 8, you stop at 6. No set in this plan goes to failure. Most lifters underestimate how many reps they have left, so in week 1 be honest rather than cautious. If you hit the top of the range on every set in week 1 with two reps still in reserve, the load is too light. Add a step the next session.

The warm-up

Five to ten minutes. The same every session.

- Three minutes easy on a bike, rower or incline walk, enough to raise your temperature
- One minute of arm circles and leg swings, both directions
- For the first lift of the session, ramp-up sets: 50 percent of your working load for 8 to 10, 75 percent for 5 or 6, 90 percent for 2 or 3. Rest a minute between them. Then the working sets.
- For every lift after the first, one lighter set of 8 to 10 if the muscle hasn't been loaded yet that session. Otherwise go straight in.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	LOAD RULE	NOTES
1	Load finding	Bottom of each rep range, two reps left	Every set is a test. Write every number down.
2	Build	Same load, add reps toward the top of the range	Two reps in reserve on every set.
3	Build	When every set hits the top of the range, add 5 lb to compounds and 2.5 lb to isolation lifts, drop back to the bottom	Hardest week of the block.
4	Deload	Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of week 3 load, three to four reps in reserve	Nothing hard. The week exists so weeks 5 to 7 work.
5	Build from the new loads	Resume week 3 loads, full sets, bottom of the range	Should feel easier than week 3.
6	Build	Add reps, then load, same rule as week 3	Two reps in reserve.
7	Build	Add reps, then load	Second hardest week. The deload is next, so do not save anything.
8	Deload and re-test	Half the sets at 80 to 90 percent on everything except the first lift of each session, which repeats week 1 load, sets and reps	Log the difference on each first lift. That is your number.

The progression rule

The plan runs on double progression with a two-reps-in-reserve cap. Every exercise has a rep range. You start at the bottom of the range with the load you found in week 1. Each session you try to add a rep to each set, stopping two reps from failure. When every working set of an exercise hits the top of the range with two reps still in reserve, you add load the next session: 5 lb on a compound lift (a press, a row, a squat, a deadlift, a pull-up), 2.5 lb on an isolation lift (a raise, a curl, an extension, a fly, a calf raise). Then you drop back to the bottom of the range and climb again. If the gym's smallest plates don't allow a 2.5 lb step, use the next machine pin or the next dumbbell and accept a bigger drop in reps.

The block structure matters because of the cap. Three weeks of building at two reps from failure, six days a week, accumulates fatigue that doesn't show up on any single day. Week 4 and week 8 drain it. In a deload week you run every session, every exercise, at half the working sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, and you stop three to four reps from failure. The deload is not optional and it is not a reward. Skipping it is how the second block stalls.

A deload also fires early if any one of these happens, in the same week it happens, and then you resume the schedule where you were:

- Performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy
- A week of bad sleep

The week 8 re-test is simple. On the first lift of each session (bench, deadlift, squat, incline dumbbell press, lat pulldown, Romanian deadlift) you load the bar to your week 1 starting weight and do week 1's sets and reps.

Then you do as many reps as the two-in-reserve rule allows on the last set and write down the difference. Everything else in week 8 is deload volume.

The sessions

Tempo is written as four digits: seconds down, pause at the bottom, seconds up, pause at the top. 3-0-1-0 is three seconds down, no pause, one second up, no pause. 3-1-1-0 adds a one-second pause in the stretched position. The three-second lowering phase is the rule on every rep of every exercise unless the table says otherwise. It is slower than you want. That is the point.

Every set in every table stops two reps from failure. "Per side" means do all the reps on one side, then the other, then rest.

Day 1: Push A, heavy

Focus: compound pressing strength. Whole chest, front and side delts, triceps.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Flat barbell bench press	3	6–8	3-0-1-0	3 min	Ramp-up sets first. Bar to the lower chest, feet planted, shoulder blades pulled down and back.
Incline barbell press, 30 to 45 degrees	3	6–8	3-0-1-0	2–3 min	Bar to the upper chest. The incline lines up with the upper chest fibres.
Standing barbell overhead press	3	6–8	3-0-1-0	2–3 min	Glutes tight, ribs down. Press straight up, not forward.
Weighted dips, chest emphasis	3	8–10	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Lean forward, elbows out at about 45 degrees. Bodyweight if weighted puts you under 8 reps.
Dumbbell lateral raise, slight forward lean	3	12–15	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Lean forward 10 to 15 degrees. Lead with the elbows, stop at shoulder height.
Overhead cable triceps extension, rope	3	10–12	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Elbows high, full stretch behind the head at the bottom.

Substitutions: barbell bench → machine chest press, flat dumbbell press, cable press, push-up with feet raised. Incline barbell → incline machine press, incline dumbbell press, low-to-high cable press, incline push-up. Overhead press → machine shoulder press, seated dumbbell press, cable overhead press, pike push-up. Weighted dips → machine dip, decline dumbbell press, cable decline press, bodyweight dips or bench dips. Lateral raise → machine lateral raise, same movement with dumbbells, cable lateral raise, no bodyweight equivalent. Overhead cable extension → machine extension, single dumbbell overhead extension, rope pushdown, close-grip push-up.

Day 2: Pull A, heavy

Focus: compound pulling strength. Posterior chain, lat width, upper back thickness, rear delts.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Conventional deadlift	3	5–7	3-1-1-0	3–4 min	Ramp-up sets first. Dead stop on the floor each rep. Brace, push the floor away, lock out tall.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Weighted pull-up, shoulder-width grip	3	6–8	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Elbows to the ribs, chest to the bar. Pause one second at the bottom hang. Bodyweight or assisted if weighted puts you under 6.
Chest-supported T-bar row	3	8–10	3-1-1-0	2 min	Pull to the sternum, squeeze the shoulder blades together. The chest pad takes the lower back out of it after deadlifts.
Wide-grip cable row to the upper chest	3	10–12	3-1-1-0	90 sec	Wide handle, pull to the collarbone. Upper back and rear delts.
Barbell curl, shoulder-width grip	3	8–10	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Standing, elbows pinned, no swing from the hips.
Face pull, rope to the forehead	3	15–20	2-0-1-1	60 sec	Pull the rope apart and rotate the hands back at the end. One-second hold.

Substitutions: deadlift → trap bar deadlift, heavy dumbbell Romanian deadlift, no cable equivalent, no bodyweight equivalent (if no barbell, run Romanian deadlift with what you have). Pull-up → lat pulldown, no dumbbell equivalent, cable pulldown, inverted row. T-bar row → chest-supported machine row, chest-supported dumbbell row, seated cable row, inverted row. Wide cable row → machine high row, bent-over dumbbell row with elbows out, same movement on a cable with a different handle, no bodyweight equivalent. Barbell curl → machine curl, dumbbell curl, cable curl, no bodyweight equivalent. Face pull → reverse pec deck, bent-over rear delt raise, same movement with a band, no bodyweight equivalent.

Day 3: Legs A, quad focus

Focus: compound leg strength, quads, with one hamstring movement to prepare the posterior chain for Day 6.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Back squat, high bar	3	6–8	3-1-1-0	3–4 min	Ramp-up sets first. Bar on the traps, torso upright, knees travel forward. Pause one second at the bottom.
Leg press, feet mid-platform, shoulder width	3	10–12	3-1-1-0	2 min	Full range, knees track over the toes. The spine is out of the lift here, so push the range.
Bulgarian split squat, dumbbells	3	10–12 per side	3-1-1-0	90 sec	Upright torso, front knee forward. Rest after both sides.
Leg extension, toes neutral	3	12–15	3-0-1-1	60 sec	Full lockout with a one-second squeeze at the top.
Romanian deadlift, barbell	3	10–12	3-1-1-0	90 sec	Hinge at the hips, bar close to the shins, pause one second at the stretch.
Standing calf raise, toes straight	3	15–20	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Interset stretch: after the last rep of each set, sink into the bottom stretch and hold it 20 to 30 seconds, then rest. It should be intense, not painful.

Substitutions: back squat → hack squat, goblet squat or dumbbell front squat, no cable equivalent, bodyweight squat with a pause. Leg press → hack squat, dumbbell squat, no cable equivalent, bodyweight squat for high reps. Bulgarian split squat → single-leg leg press, same movement with dumbbells or a barbell, no cable

equivalent, bodyweight split squat. Leg extension → no machine alternative, no dumbbell equivalent, no cable equivalent, sissy squat. Romanian deadlift → lying leg curl, dumbbell Romanian deadlift, cable pull-through, partner-held bodyweight hamstring curl. Standing calf raise → seated calf raise, single-leg calf raise holding a dumbbell, leg press calf raise, single-leg bodyweight calf raise on a step.

Day 4: Push B, volume

Focus: higher reps, deeper stretch, more sets. Upper chest line, delt detail, both ends of the triceps.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Incline dumbbell press, 30 degrees	3	10–12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Ramp-up sets first. Elbows 45 degrees from the torso, let the dumbbells go deeper than a bar would.
Flat dumbbell press	3	10–12	3-0-1-0	2 min	Lower to the nipple line, wrists neutral. Each arm works alone, so note any side that lags.
Low-to-high cable fly	3	12–15	3-0-1-1	90 sec	Start with the handles low, finish with the hands together above chest height. One-second squeeze.
Seated dumbbell shoulder press	3	10–12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Press in a slight arc, up and slightly back. No leg drive.
Single-arm cable lateral raise	3	12–15 per side	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Cable runs behind the body. Tension from the first inch, which a dumbbell cannot give you.
Rope pushdown	3	12–15	3-0-1-1	60 sec	Elbows pinned to the sides, pull the rope apart at the bottom, one-second squeeze.
Overhead dumbbell triceps extension, single dumbbell	2	15–20	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Both hands on one dumbbell. Deep stretch behind the head, full lockout.

Substitutions: incline dumbbell press → incline machine press, same movement, incline cable press, incline push-up. Flat dumbbell press → machine chest press, same movement, cable press, push-up. Cable fly → pec deck, flat dumbbell fly, same movement from a different cable height, no bodyweight equivalent. Seated dumbbell press → machine shoulder press, same movement standing, cable overhead press, pike push-up. Cable lateral raise → machine lateral raise, dumbbell lateral raise, same movement with the cable in front of the body, no bodyweight equivalent. Rope pushdown → machine triceps extension, dumbbell kickback, straight-bar pushdown, bench dip. Overhead dumbbell extension → machine extension, same movement one arm at a time, overhead rope extension, close-grip push-up.

Day 5: Pull B, volume

Focus: lat width and sweep, scapular control, biceps peak and thickness, rear delts.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Lat pulldown, wide pronated grip	3	10–12	3-1-1-0	2 min	One ramp-up set first. Elbows down and back, slight lean back, pause one second at the top stretch.
Seated cable row, close neutral grip	3	10–12	3-0-1-2	2 min	Pull to the lower sternum, squeeze the shoulder blades together for two seconds.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Single-arm dumbbell row, elbow out	3	12–15 per side	3-1-1-0	90 sec	Elbow 45 degrees from the body, pull to the hip, let the lat stretch at the bottom.
Straight-arm pulldown, rope	3	12–15	3-0-1-1	90 sec	Arms straight, lean forward, pull to the hips. The lat does the work, not the arm.
Incline dumbbell curl	3	10–12	3-0-1-0	90 sec	Bench at 45 degrees, arms hang straight down behind you. Do not let the elbows drift forward.
Hammer curl, alternating	3	12–15 per side	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Neutral grip, curl to the shoulder. Alternate arms, count reps per arm.
Reverse pec deck	2	15–20	2-0-1-1	60 sec	Arms parallel to the floor, one-second hold at the back.

Substitutions: lat pulldown → machine pulldown, dumbbell pullover, same movement with a different attachment, pull-up or assisted pull-up. Seated cable row → machine row, chest-supported dumbbell row, same movement with a different handle, inverted row with a narrow grip. Single-arm dumbbell row → single-arm machine row, same movement, single-arm cable row, no bodyweight equivalent. Straight-arm pulldown → machine pullover, dumbbell pullover, same movement with a straight bar, no bodyweight equivalent. Incline curl → machine preacher curl, same movement, cable curl from behind the body, no bodyweight equivalent. Hammer curl → machine neutral-grip curl, same movement, rope cable hammer curl, no bodyweight equivalent. Reverse pec deck → face pull on a machine row, bent-over dumbbell rear delt raise, cable rear delt fly, no bodyweight equivalent.

Day 6: Legs B, hamstring and glute focus

Focus: hip extension, hamstring knee-flexion work, glutes, with one quad finisher and calves.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Romanian deadlift, barbell	3	8–10	3-1-1-0	2–3 min	Ramp-up sets first. Hip hinge, chest up, bar scrapes the shins, one-second pause at the stretch. Heavier than Day 3's version.
Leg press, feet high and wide	3	12–15	3-1-1-0	2 min	Feet near the top of the platform, toes out about 15 degrees. Deep. Glutes, not quads.
Walking lunge, dumbbells	3	12–15 steps per side	2-0-1-0	90 sec	Long stride, upright torso, drive through the heel.
Lying leg curl	3	12–15	3-0-1-1	90 sec	Toes pointed down, full contraction with a one-second hold.
Barbell hip thrust, feet forward	3	12–15	2-0-1-2	90 sec	Shoulders on the bench, drive through the heels, squeeze the glutes for two seconds at the top.
Sissy squat, bodyweight or light dumbbell	2	15–20	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Knees forward, lean back, heels raised. A finisher, not a strength lift.
Seated calf raise	3	15–20	3-0-1-0	60 sec	Knees bent 90 degrees. Interset stretch on every set, same as Day 3.

Substitutions: Romanian deadlift → lying leg curl at higher load, dumbbell Romanian deadlift, cable pull-through, single-leg bodyweight Romanian deadlift. Leg press high and wide → hack squat with high feet, dumbbell sumo squat, no cable equivalent, wide-stance bodyweight squat. Walking lunge → single-leg leg press, same movement, no cable equivalent, bodyweight reverse lunge. Lying leg curl → seated leg curl, no dumbbell equivalent, cable leg curl with an ankle strap, slider or ball hamstring curl. Hip thrust → machine hip thrust, dumbbell hip thrust, cable pull-through, single-leg bodyweight hip thrust. Sissy squat → leg extension, goblet squat with heels raised, no cable equivalent, bodyweight is the default. Seated calf raise → leg press calf raise with bent knees, no dumbbell equivalent, no cable equivalent, bent-knee bodyweight calf raise.

The week

DAY	SESSION
Monday	Push A, heavy
Tuesday	Pull A, heavy
Wednesday	Legs A, quad focus
Thursday	Push B, volume
Friday	Pull B, volume
Saturday	Legs B, hamstring and glute focus
Sunday	Off

The rolling alternative. If a fixed seven-day week doesn't fit your life, run the sessions in order with a rest day after every third: Push A, Pull A, Legs A, rest, Push B, Pull B, Legs B, rest, then start again. Each muscle is trained every four days instead of twice in seven, which is a slightly higher frequency, and you train five or six days out of every seven. The A and B sessions still alternate. The only rule is the order, so write the next session on the calendar as you finish the current one.

Progression and troubleshooting

Adding load

The rule is in the eight-weeks section. Reps first, then load. When every set of an exercise reaches the top of its range with two reps in reserve, add 5 lb to a compound lift or 2.5 lb to an isolation lift and drop back to the bottom of the range. Never add load because a set felt easy. Add load because the log says every set hit the number.

A stalled lift

A lift is stalled when two sessions in a row show the same reps at the same load. First, hold the load and keep trying to add a rep. Give it two more sessions. If it moves, carry on. If two weeks pass with no change, drop the load by 10 percent and climb back up. Most stalls on this plan are fatigue, not strength. A 10 percent drop resets the climb and you usually pass the old number within three sessions.

Intensity techniques

The template this plan grew from uses four techniques to push a set past failure. Mechanical drop set: hit failure on a hard variation, then switch at once to an easier one and continue. Rest-pause: hit failure, rest 10 to 15 seconds in position, go again. Cluster set: hit failure, take one breath, go again, up to four times. Interset stretch: after the last rep of a set, hold the stretched position 20 to 30 seconds.

This plan uses one of them, the interset stretch, on calves only. It is a stretch hold, not a failure set, so it fits under the two-reps-in-reserve cap. The other three all require training to failure, and failure six days a week is what this plan is built to avoid. Know what they are. Leave them out for these eight weeks.

A missed session

Slot it in on the next available day and push everything after it back by one. Never double up. Two sessions in one day gives you two bad sessions. If you miss two sessions in the same week, the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B from the compliance page and come back to the full week the following Monday.

Poor sleep

On a day after a bad night, cap the volume: two working sets instead of three on everything, and stop three reps from failure instead of two. Nothing goes to the edge. Log the session as a cap day so the lower numbers don't read as a stall.

When to stop

Muscle fatigue is normal. Burning, heaviness, soreness a day or two later. Pain that is sharp, in a joint, or that changes how you move is not. Stop the session and see a professional. This is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walk most days, 20 to 40 minutes. That is the default and it costs nothing in recovery. Walk before breakfast, after dinner, or in two short pieces. It counts the same.

On a six-day lifting plan, hard cardio stays light. If you want more than walking, 15 to 20 minutes of easy work after a lifting session, at a pace where you can hold a conversation, is as far as it goes. Bike, incline walk, rower. Never before lifting, and nothing on the day before a leg session that would leave your legs tired for it. Intervals, sprints and anything that leaves you flat for the next session are off the table for these eight weeks. Sunday is a rest day, which means a walk and nothing else.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- All six sessions done
- All six sessions logged, every set with load and reps
- Protein hit every day, 1 g per pound of bodyweight as the default
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded
- Walks done on most days

Plan B, the bare minimum

A full week, when the week blows up, is three sessions: one push, one pull, one legs. Run Push A, Pull A and Legs A. Protein is still hit every day. That is the whole rule. Three sessions logged with protein hit is a week that counts, and the plan resumes at full size the following Monday.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom
- Photos front, side, back
- Read the whole of week 1 before Day 1
- Set the six session days in a calendar, with the rest day
- Pick the Plan B days now, before you need them

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

Stephen Dugger · The Sovereign Method · stephendugger.com · steve@stephendugger.com

Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.